

Brief 5. Approach Note

Objective, method, and structure. For adaptation into the draft.

Series context

This brief is the fifth in the Independent Monitoring and Evaluation Reviews of Nigerian Social Investment Programmes series. The first four briefs each took a single Nigerian federal programme and assessed it against its stated objectives, its budget disclosures, and its independent evidence base. NASSP-HUP, AGILE, the Home Grown School Feeding Programme, and N-Power.

Brief 5 takes a different frame. Instead of one programme, it takes one instrument, the Conditional Cash Transfer, and traces its journey from origin in Mexico in 1997, through Latin American diffusion, Asian adoption, African adaptation, and into Nigeria's COPE (2007) and NASSP-HUP (2016 to present). The reason for the change of frame is that four briefs on individual programmes have already established a set of failure patterns in Nigerian social investment. Brief 5 tests whether those failures are Nigerian in origin or whether they are inherited from an instrument that carries the same design weaknesses wherever it is transplanted.

Main objective

To answer, with grounded evidence rather than opinion, one question:

Is cash transfer (conditional or unconditional) a sound national response to poverty, and for what specific objectives does it actually work or not?

The brief exists because in Nigeria, and increasingly across the region, cash transfers are being promoted as the flagship poverty response, often with limited public debate on what the international evidence base actually shows. The verdict at the end of this brief will be direct. Cash transfers work for certain objectives under certain conditions, and they do not work as a general national poverty solution divorced from those conditions. The task of the brief is to establish, source by source and country by country, what those objectives and conditions are.

Secondary objectives

- Establish, in one place, the pre-history of the CCT paradigm. That is, who invented it, why, and whether it was an international agency invention or a Southern government innovation later codified by international agencies.
- Trace, chronologically and country by country, how the instrument travelled and mutated as it moved through different national contexts.
- Set the Nigerian case (COPE and NASSP-HUP) inside the international pattern, rather than treating Nigeria as an isolated national story.
- Produce, at the end, a specific recommendations section for Nigeria's CCT architecture that follows directly from the evidence pattern established in the earlier sections.

Methodology

The core method: chronological country genealogy plus synthesis

The method has two moves. The first move is to tell each country's story in the order in which each country adopted CCT, on the same five points every time. Who introduced it. Why. For what stated problem. How it was implemented. What happened. The second move is to aggregate the country stories at the end and derive the verdict from the pattern that emerges.

This method is deliberate and it rules out two alternatives that would not work for this brief. It is not a systematic literature review, because a systematic review would produce an academic output that the policy reader would not use. It is not a polemic, because a polemic would collapse the country evidence into a single argument without letting the reader see the variation that matters. The chronological genealogy holds both together. The reader encounters each country on its own terms, and then encounters the pattern.

Synthesis of syntheses, not re-evaluation

There are more than one hundred and fifty rigorous evaluations of CCT programmes globally. This brief does not attempt to re-evaluate each programme from primary sources. That work has already been done by the systematic review community. The method used here is synthesis of syntheses. Foundational cross-country reviews carry the aggregate evidence. Country-specific sources add texture on the design and political adoption of each programme. This is a legitimate and standard research method (umbrella review) and it is the only tractable way to answer the target question in forty pages.

The five-point country story frame

Every country section uses the same five points, in the same order. This is the discipline that lets the aggregate section at the end compare like with like.

- Who introduced it. Named political actor plus institutional sponsor (World Bank, IADB, UNICEF, or none).
- Why. The specific national moment and stated rationale.
- For what problem. The primary objective the programme was designed to address (poverty relief, human capital, health service uptake, gender equity, or shock response).
- How it was implemented. Design features: conditionality, targeting method, transfer size, payment rails, verification.
- What happened. Documented outcomes against the stated objective, plus documented failure modes.

Source discipline

The brief works within three hard caps that were locked at the outset to prevent scope drift.

- Maximum forty pages.
- Maximum forty sources.
- Maximum four charts.

Source structure

The sources are organised in four blocks. Foundational sources sit above the country stories and frame the whole brief. Country-story sources carry one main citation per country. Nigeria sources carry the domestic evidence. Cross-cutting sources support the aggregate section.

- Foundational (F1 to F6). Six sources. Fiszbein and Schady 2009 (World Bank Policy Research Report), Bastagli et al. 2016 (ODI rigorous review of 165 studies), Fenwick 2009 (pre-history Brazil), Hanlon, Barrientos and Hulme 2010 (Global South paradigm), and the World Bank Nigeria NASSP documents (ICR Review 2024 and Scale-Up PAD 2024).
- Country stories (S1 to S11). One main source per country: Mexico, Brazil, Latin American regional, Philippines, Indonesia, India, Ghana, Kenya, Malawi, South Africa, Tanzania.
- Nigeria (N1 to N3). COPE evidence, NASSP-HUP journalism, and cross-reference to Brief 4 (N-Power).
- Cross-cutting (X1, X2). Conditional versus unconditional cash transfer review, and sub-Saharan Africa cash transfer review.

This gives twenty two firm sources. Up to eighteen supporting citations can be added for specific claims, drawn from the existing set of one hundred and fifty five CCT papers already assembled. Total ceiling remains forty.

Structure of the brief (eleven sections)

Part One. The idea before the framework

- Section 1. Is Conditional Cash Transfer an International Organisation Invention? Pre-history 1975 to 1996. Bangladesh FSSSP 1994, Brasilia and Campinas municipal experiments 1995, Honduras PRAF 1990. The myths CCT innovators had to fight (the poor are lazy, the poor cannot manage money).

Part Two. The instrument crystallises and diffuses

- Section 2. The instrument and the moment. What CCT is technically, why cash won over alternatives, why conditional.
- Section 3. Mexico 1997. Progresas, Oportunidades, Prospera.
- Section 4. Brazil 2003. Bolsa Familia, from municipal experiments to national programme.
- Section 5. Latin American diffusion, 2000 to 2010. Colombia, Nicaragua, Honduras, Jamaica, Ecuador, Chile, Peru, Bolivia, Uruguay.
- Section 6. Asia adoption. Philippines 4Ps, Indonesia PKH, India JSY.
- Section 7. Africa adoption. Ghana LEAP, Kenya CT-OVC, Malawi Zomba, South Africa HPTN 068 and CSG, Tanzania PSSN. Mostly weakened or unconditional. What that shift shows about the instrument's supply-side dependencies.

Part Three. Nigeria

- Section 8. Nigeria 2007 to 2026. COPE, then NASSP-HUP. Design fidelity to the Progresas template, quiet deviations, the National Social Register, ghost-name and stipend erosion problems traced from Brief 4.

Part Four. Aggregate and answer

- Section 9. What the pattern shows. Pull the country stories together. What worked reliably, what worked sometimes, what did not work. Chart 1 (transfer size in USD across programmes), Chart 2 (coverage share), Chart 3 (Nigeria real-value trajectory versus comparators).
- Section 10. Verdict on cash as national response. Direct answer to the target question, evidence trail from sections three to nine as support.

- Section 11. Recommendations for Nigeria's CCT architecture. Named, actionable, grounded in section nine and ten. Chart 4 (recommended architecture).

What this brief contributes

There is currently no single publicly available Nigerian document that traces the CCT instrument's international origin, its diffusion pattern, and its Nigerian implementation record in one readable brief. Individual academic papers exist for each country. Systematic reviews exist for the aggregate evidence. World Bank documents exist for the Nigerian programme. None of them speak to each other in a single document written for a Nigerian policy reader.

Brief 5 fills that gap. It puts the Nigerian conversation about cash transfers inside the international pattern it belongs to, so that Nigerian policy readers can see, on one desk, where the instrument came from, what it has done elsewhere, and what should reasonably be expected of it here.